



**New woman:** Self-sufficiency is the route most women are adopting today

politics in India has the potential to increase the presence of women and lead to a new consciousness for them.

Today, over a 100 countries have instituted gender quotas. Evidence suggests they can increase female heads in politics over and above the initial quota. Rwanda, a country with 30 per cent gender quota in the national Parliament, has just become the first country where female parliamentarians constitute a majority. In India, gender quotas exist in panchayats—33 per cent of all elected positions are reserved for women. No seat is reserved twice, rather, the quota is rotated across seats at every election. Evidence from municipal wards in Mumbai and panchayats in West Bengal shows that reservation increases overall participation of women in politics. The West Bengal study collected data on voter attitudes by measuring villagers' reactions to, among others, recorded speeches that portrayed a hypothetical leader discussing village decisions. The gender of the leader randomly varied. In villages where the pradhan position had never been reserved, villagers evaluated the speech more positively

when the speaker's voice was manipulated to be male. These biases were significantly reduced among villagers, who had been exposed to female pradhans.

There were huge gender differences as well—while female villagers appeared less biased to start with, exposure to female pradhans also affected them less. This is probably because female villagers were less likely to be involved in or even aware of the political process—an issue that could have significant public policy implications.

Taken together, this evidence makes a case for using gender quotas to break down the institutional barriers and voter perceptions, which hinder female entry in politics. The form in which quotas are implemented is also critical and it is argued that the panchayat model is an appropriate one. In Indian panchayats, one-third of seats are reserved for women. Women compete with other women for a reserved seat, but recognise that in future elections they would have to face competition from both men and women.

Indian politics is characterised by incumbency disadvantage. So even though rotation of seats imposes, in effect, term limits for male and female pradhans, this is unlikely to have consequences for the quality of governance. Finally, it is critical

the choice of reserved seats be governed by a set of clear rules, which ensures all seats are equally likely to be reserved. In a recently published work, professors Frechette, Maniquet and Morelli have shown the pitfalls of a quota policy, which requires parties to field a number of women but leaves the choice of where to field them up to political parties.

Seeing women leaders in politics is likely to have important ripple-down effects. Weakening of such stereotypes can reduce individual bias against women leaders in other arenas, such as high-power corporate jobs. As more and more women are elected to leadership positions, one would also hope it would encourage women citizens take a more active role in the political arena.

*with Alexandra Cirone, research manager, Micro-development Initiative, Harvard Kennedy School*

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**IS THE PERCENTAGE OF WOMEN NATIONAL LEGISLATORS IN INDIA; COMPARED TO A GLOBAL AVERAGE OF 18 PER CENT.**